Egypt Seshat Presentation

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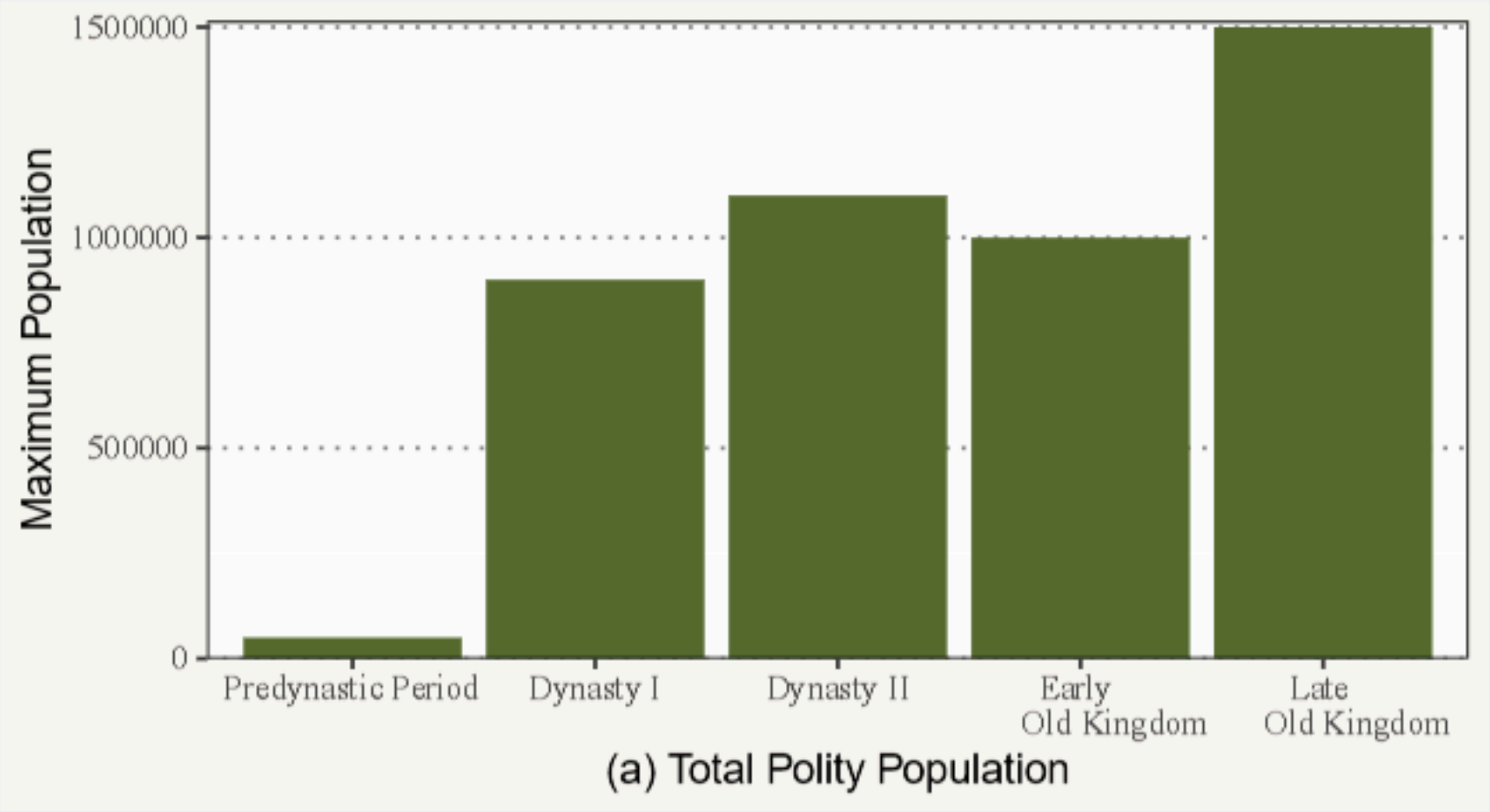
Plotting Rise and Decline in Egypt's Old Kingdom

Predynastic to the the First Intermediate Period

What does systemic decline look like in ancient times?

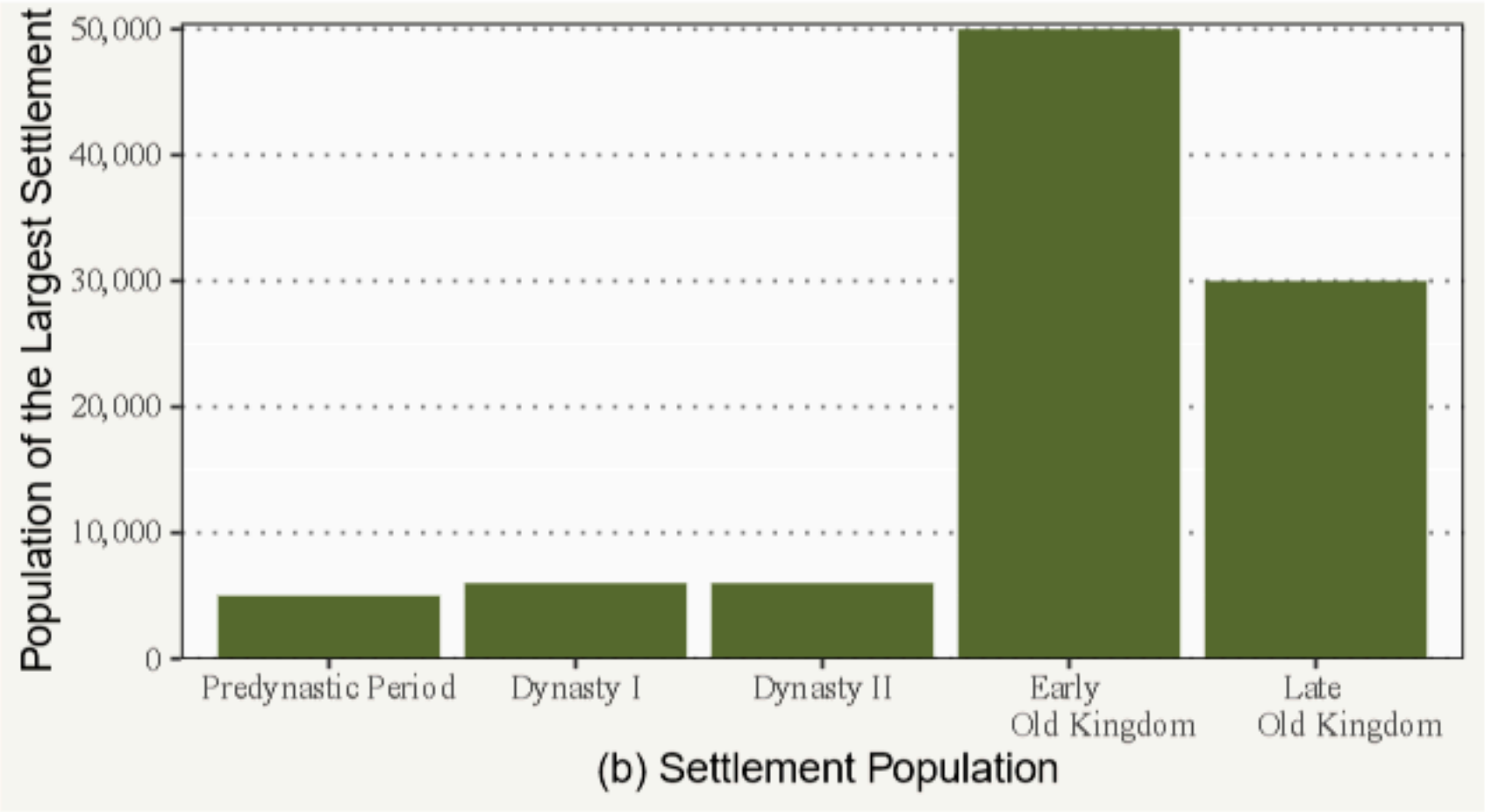
Ancient Egypt's Old Kingdom decline resulted in the rise of provincial governors, called *Nomarchs*, who dissected the kingdom. This data looks at Upper Egypt, the southern provinces farther from the capital in Memphis.

Over the course of the Old Kingdom, Upper Egypt's population steadily increased.



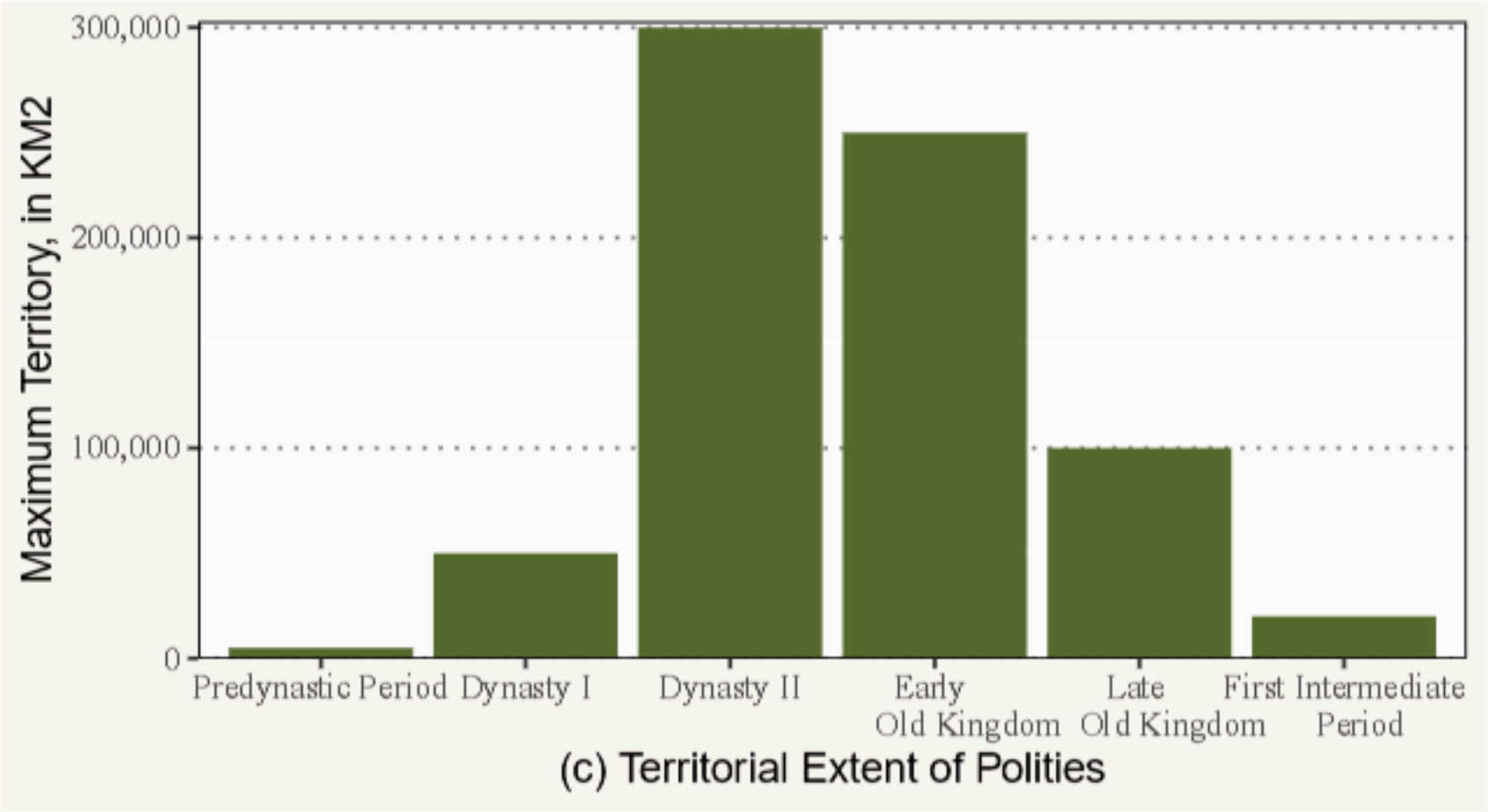
Centralization

The Old Kingdom centralized Egypt, and built Egypt's first true cities. Settlement population expanded. Measurements form the First Intermediate period, however, show a decline in maximum settlement population


Population of the Largest Settlement
50,000
40,000
30,000
20,000
10,000
0
Predynastic Period
Dynasty I
Dynasty II
Early Old Kingdom
Late Old Kingdom
(b) Settlement Population

Territorial Extent

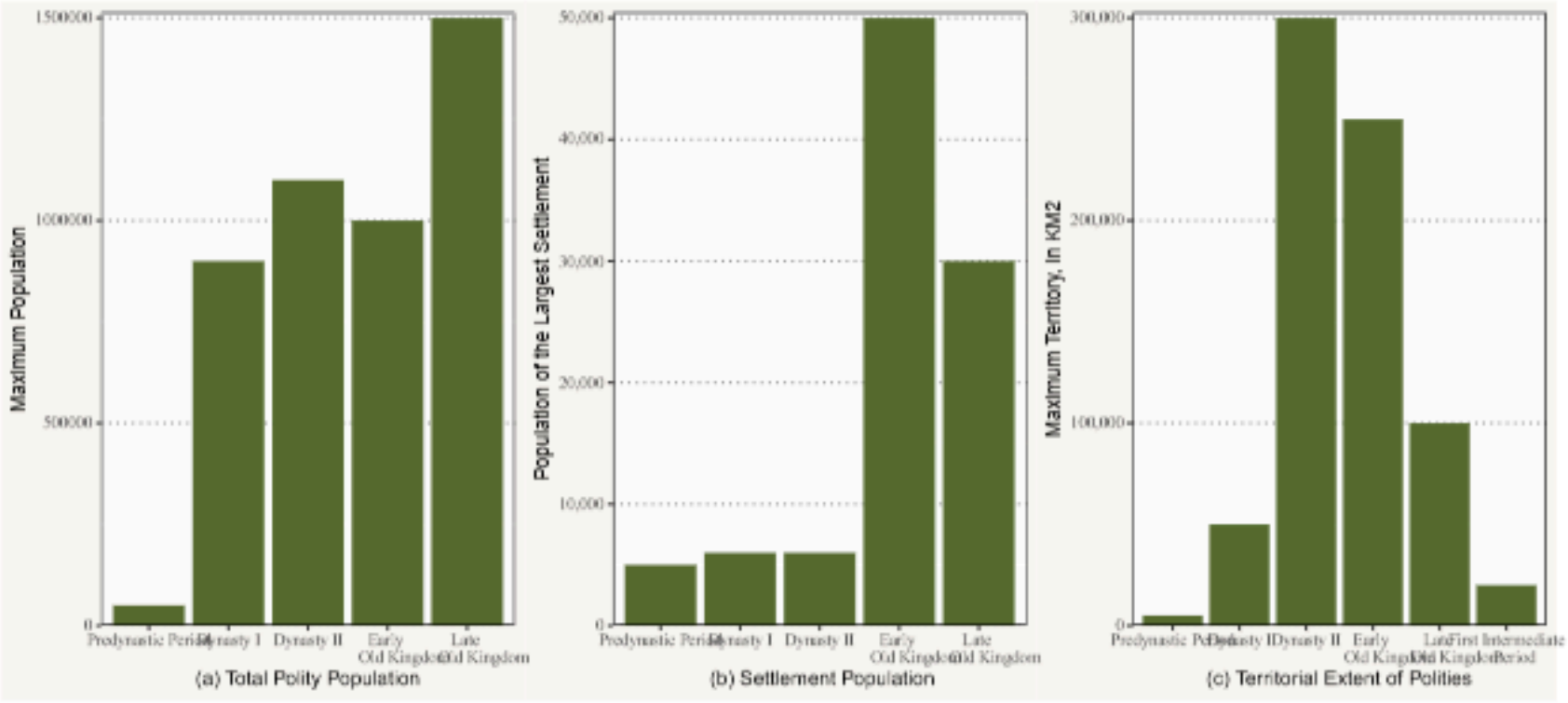
Lastly, we can see that the maximum extent of Egypt's polities decreased over time, indicating a breakdown of central authority.


Maximum Territory, in KM2
300,000
200,000
100,000
0
Predynastic Period
Dynasty I
Dynasty II
Early Old Kingdom
Late Old Kingdom
First Intermediate Period
(c) Territorial Extent of Polities

Synthesized Output

Population and Territory in Ancient Egypt

From Predynastic Egypt to the First Intermediate Period (3,300–2,055 BCE)



Analysis

We can see that increased rurification combined with increased total population signals a breakdown in central authority and command in Upper Egypt. Please consult the `README` for a complete breakdown and analysis.